

for fast-tracking the establishment of the franchise's academy in Thane, which has produced championship-winning players for the side. "If you look at acquiring players from the auction, you barely get a few weeks to know the player and build team patterns around them. We can't hold players for long. Retention policies eased those stresses a bit, but we still have a long way to go there. Most of the boys you see now have been with us since season eight, but these are academy-groomed players rather than pure scouting acquisitions," he explains. Kandpal, however, does stress that the return on investment is quite small in terms of the number of players an academy can fashion into stars. He calls Inamdar and Goyat, the star duo of the Paltan, outliers rather than the norm, which makes kinder retention rules even more important.

Suhail Chandhok, CEO of U Mumba, is into his second season in the role after calling the game on broadcast since the league's inception. His entrepreneurial ventures into the sport involved setting up the Yuva Kabaddi Series and several other grassroots initiatives to churn talent for higher levels of the sport. He finds the current auction structure antithetical to the tendency franchises have. "Job security is one of the biggest anxieties players carry in this league. But the biggest problem, and the biggest frustration for me and many other team owners, is that when we sign a player, there's no guarantee that we will have this player for the next five years. As franchises, we might invest in Arjun Deshwal (**right**), Abhishek Singh, or Siddharth Desai, but in two years' time, they could well be floating off to another team. The league needs to address this.

"Locking players down and building teams and systems around them has commercial value for the outfit and the fan base. Look at what

Anup Kumar and legendary Iranian defender Fazel Atrachali (**facing page**) commanded at U Mumba. The youngsters coming through will also do that, but where is the guarantee? Where is the security for the investment I am making in that player? PKL is the second-biggest sporting league in the country, it's time we act like it and evolve from the patterns of the first decade. Long-term contracts, trading windows, player policies, exit clauses for teams to also be secure should all be on the table," he adds.

Globalisation in limbo

While the COVID-19 pandemic emerged

as a massive curveball to the sporting world as a whole, kabaddi and the PKL made a strong statement of intent by becoming the first contact sport to conduct a full-fledged league during the pandemic, albeit behind closed doors.

That said, inconsistencies in the sport's global scene predate the COVID era. World Cups sometimes come with gaps of over 8-10 years. Fazel told this publication a few years ago that the lack of robustly

scheduled tournaments had

robbed him of medals he would have otherwise definitely won. This season, he is more cynical at the mention of a scheduled world event in 2025. "I'll believe it when it happens," he said.

For franchises in the PKL, the bigger concern is having a player pool that has nothing to do outside of the domestic

SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

THE LEAGUE, AFTER GOING THROUGH THE 12-CITY RIGMAROLE LAST SEASON, HAS RETURNED TO A THREE-VENUE SET-UP THIS TIME WITH A TWO-FOLD MOTIVE